

The Highlands University baseball team opens the early season tomorrow when they travel to the University of Texas-El Paso.

The UTEP four game series will be the opener for both clubs. HU's 1977 40-game baseball schedule boasts 22 contests with NCAA clubs.

Coach John Donnelly's HU Cowboys will be hoping to rebound from last season's disappointing 9-19 mark. Only seven veterans return to this season's HU 29 man roster and Donnelly promises his club will have more depth at the pitching position.

Two El Paso Jefferson High School natives, sophomore David Del Toro and Junior Manuel Rivera, are expected to get the starting pitching nods in Friday's doubleheader at UTEP. Del Toro, 2-5 last season, is a righthander will go in the front game with southpaw Rivera (2-1) starting the second game.

Freshman New York natives, Frank McShea and Ron Nieldsweiski, both righthanders are expected to go on Saturday. Donnelly has indicated that sophomore Robert Cornell, a righthander from Massachusetts and Islip, New York's Victor Nicotra, a freshman righthander will be ready for long relief.

The Cowboys will only have two veterans in the probable starting lineup this weekend. Senior captain David Munoz (.261 and 13 rbi's 1976) will be at shortstop and sophomore Curt Cook (.333 and 20 rbi's 1976) will be at third base. Transfer Eleazar Vasquez, formerly of Pan American University, will be at first base with Massachusetts sophomore Tom Sullivan at second and freshman David Howard behind the plate.

Staten Island freshman Dan Manochio will be in centerfield, freshman David Ramirez of Hebbronville, Tex., in right and Manuel Rivera is the scheduled leftfielder. Freshman Vinnie Larvin will be the leftfielder when Rivera takes the mound in tomorrow's second game.

"I'm looking for an exciting series," coach Donnelly said. "Andy Cohen (UTEP baseball coach) said he felt his team was better than last season's and we feel the same. I'll be really interested to see how our pitchers make the ball behave this early in the season. That is going to be one key to our success."

Last season the UTEP-NMHU series resulted in a split in El Paso. The Cowboys won the front game 7-5 and were bombed 30-3 by the Miners in the second contest.

The Miners will be in Las Vegas April 1 and 2 for a four game series.